

Why Not What

How Theology Starts With the Right Question

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LIVEWELL BY JAMES BELL

*You have made us for yourself, and our heart is restless
until it rests in you.*

— Augustine, Confessions, 397

Introduction: The Question Under the Question

For most of my life I asked the wrong question, and I asked it loudly, and I was sure it was the only serious one there was.

I came to faith out of atheism as a grown man, and I want to tell you what an atheist actually wants, because I was one and I remember. People think the unbeliever is asking what is true and waiting to be handed the evidence. That is not what is happening underneath. The question I was really asking, in the years I would have told you I was asking nothing, was not what should I believe. It was why. Why is there anything here at all. Why will this ache not leave me alone. Why does a man raised without a father spend his whole life looking for one and calling it by other names. I had built a life out of what questions, what do I want, what works, what gets me through, and not one of them ever touched the place the real question lived.

I have come to believe this is the oldest mistake in the world and the most modern one at the same time. We ask what before we ask why. We want the instructions before we have the reason. And a faith built that way, on the what before the why, will function for a while and then it will fail you exactly when you need it, because it was never standing on anything.

This is a short book about the order of the questions. It is an argument that almost everything that goes wrong in a Christian life, and a great deal of what goes wrong in a church, goes wrong right here, at the very first move, in which question we let speak first. We have made Christianity into a vast answer to the

question what should I do, and we have been baffled when people do all the things and feel nothing, when they keep every rule and lose every reason, when they can recite the what of the faith fluently and could not tell you for their life why any of it is so.

The what is not wrong. I want to say that plainly at the start. The commands are real, the practices matter, the doing is not optional. But the what was never meant to come first, and a what that comes first stops being obedience and becomes something colder and more frightened. It becomes moralism, which is the law cut off from the love that gave it, and moralism has buried more faith than doubt ever has.

So this is not a book of answers, at least not the kind you are used to. It is a book about learning to ask why again, the way a child asks it, before the world trains the question out of us. It is the book I needed when I was an atheist asking the right question and getting handed the wrong answers, and the book I needed years later as a pastor handing people the wrong answers myself. I have five sons. I am trying to teach them to ask why before they ask what, because I think it is the difference between a faith that holds and a faith that only behaves. I am still learning it. Let me show you what I have found.

Chapter One: The Wrong Question First

Walk into most of what passes for Christian help and you will notice it answers a question almost no one stopped to examine. The question is what. What are the steps. What do I do with my anxiety, my marriage, my Monday. What does the Bible say about money, in five points, by Friday. It is a whole economy of what, and it sells, because the what feels like progress. You can measure it. You can finish it. You can close the book and feel you have been given something.

I do not mock this, because I built a ministry on it for years before I understood what I was doing. People come to a pastor in pain and they ask, almost always, a what question. What do I do now. And the temptation, the kindly meant and deadly temptation, is to answer the question they asked instead of the one underneath it. To hand them a technique when what they needed was a reason. I gave a lot of good people a lot of good steps, and I watched a fair number of them do every step and come back emptier than before, and it took me too long to see why.

The reason is that the what question, asked first, is the question of someone who is afraid. Tell me what to do is what you say when you do not trust that anything holds you, when the ground feels like it could give, when the only safety you can imagine is in getting the procedure right. It is the question of the anxious and the moral, and the church is full of both, because the church has spent a generation answering the what and starving the why.

A faith built on what before why will function for a while and then fail you exactly when you need it, because it was never standing on anything.

Here is the thing the steps cannot reach. A person can do everything right and still be standing on nothing. You can pray and read and serve and tithe and parent by the book, and if you do not know why, if the whole machine is running on duty and fear and the hope that God grades on completion, then the first real grief will knock it flat, because duty cannot carry grief. Only love can carry grief, and love is a why, not a what.

So I am asking you, early, to notice how trained you are to reach for the what. To notice the relief you feel when someone hands you steps and the vague panic you feel when someone says the real work is further down, in the reason, in the why you have been skipping your whole life. That panic is worth listening to. It is telling you where the building is hollow.

Chapter Two: The First Lie Changed the Question

The oldest temptation in the Bible is not, at its root, a temptation to do a particular thing. It is a temptation to ask a different question. Read the garden again and watch the move the serpent makes, because he makes it to us every day.

God had spoken to the man and the woman as a Father speaks, in the language of why. Eat freely, all of it is yours, only not this one tree, because in the day you eat of it you will die. There is a reason given, and the reason is love, the reason is protection, the reason is a relationship in which the rule makes sense because the One who gave it can be trusted. The command sat inside a why, and inside that why it was not a burden at all.

The serpent does not start by denying the rule. He starts by lifting it out of the why. Did God really say you shall not eat of any tree. He shifts the whole conversation from why did God say this to what exactly did God say, as if the command were a contract to be parsed, a set of words to be measured against your appetite, a what floating free of the Father who spoke it. And the moment the why is gone, the command looks like nothing but restriction, an arbitrary fence around the one thing you want, and of course she ate. Anyone would. A rule cut off from its reason is unbearable, and the serpent knew it.

That is the fall, underneath the fruit. It is the migration from why to what. From trusting the One who spoke to interrogating the thing he said. From a child who asks why because he knows there is a good answer to a lawyer who asks what because he is

looking for the loophole. We have been that lawyer ever since. We come to God's word asking what are the rules and where are the edges and how much can I do, and we have forgotten that every command in the book is a sentence that begins, somewhere up the page, with because I love you.

The fall, underneath the fruit, is the migration from why to what. From trusting the One who spoke to interrogating the thing he said.

The repair of the fall, then, is not first a new set of rules. We have tried that and it does not save anyone. The repair is the recovery of the why. It is being brought back to the Father whose love makes the commands make sense again, so that obedience stops being a fence and becomes what it was in the garden, the natural shape of trust. You cannot keep a command you have severed from its reason. You can only resent it, or break it, or both. Ask any child. Ask any sinner. Ask me.

Chapter Three: The Catechism Began Where We Should

In 1647 a group of pastors and theologians in England sat down to write a catechism for children, and they had to decide what the very first thing a child should learn about God would be. They could have started anywhere. They could have started with what the Bible is, or what sin is, or what you must do to be saved. Those are all true things and all of them come later in the document. But they did not start there. They started with a why.

What is the chief end of man. That is the first question of the Westminster Shorter Catechism, and it is a why question wearing the clothes of a what. It asks the reason for the whole thing. Why are you here. What are you for. And the answer those pastors gave has outlived empires. Man's chief end is to glorify God and to enjoy him forever.

Notice they did not begin with do this and do not do that. They began with the reason a human being exists, and they put two verbs in it that we almost never put together, glorify and enjoy, duty and delight in the same breath, as if the whole point were that these were never supposed to be separate. They taught children the why first, on purpose, because they understood something we have forgotten. A child who knows why he exists can be taught what to do. A child who is only taught what to do will spend his life doing it without joy and will hand that joyless doing to his own children, and the faith will thin out across the generations until it is only manners.

I have catechized my sons with that first question, and I will tell

you what happens when a boy actually hears it. He gets quiet. Because no one had told him he was for anything. The culture had told him a thousand whats, what to want, what to wear, what to become, and not one why worth the name. And when you tell a child he was made to glorify God and to enjoy him forever, that the enjoying is not a reward for the glorifying but the same act seen from inside, something in him settles that a thousand instructions never settled.

They taught children the why first, on purpose. A child who knows why he exists can be taught what to do. A child only taught what to do will do it without joy.

We have inverted the catechism. We start our children, and our converts, and ourselves, with the what, the behavior, the rules of the house, and we get to the why eventually if we get to it at all, as a kind of advanced topic for people who have already proven they can behave. The pastors of 1647 knew better. Begin with the reason. The reason can hold a life. The rules never could.

Chapter Four: Eleven Chapters Before the Therefore

If you want to see the right order set in stone, read Romans, and watch where Paul puts the first instruction.

The letter to the Romans is the most systematic thing Paul ever wrote, the closest the New Testament comes to a sustained argument laid out on purpose, and it has a structure that should stop us cold. For eleven chapters Paul tells you almost nothing to do. Eleven chapters. He tells you what is wrong with the world and what is wrong with you, he tells you what God has done about it in Christ, he tells you about grace and faith and the death you died with Jesus and the life you now have, he climbs all the way up into the deep places of election and mercy and the unsearchable wisdom of God until he is not even arguing anymore, he is singing. From him and through him and to him are all things, to him be glory forever. That is the end of chapter eleven. Eleven chapters of why, and not one imperative worth the name.

And then comes chapter twelve, and the first word is therefore. I appeal to you therefore, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies as a living sacrifice. There is the first real command of the letter, and Paul will not let you reach it except across the word therefore, which means because of all that, on the ground of all that, in light of the eleven chapters of why you just walked through. The what arrives, finally, but it arrives standing on a foundation so deep you could build a life on it. By the mercies of God. That is the why, and Paul will not give you a single what

until the why is unmistakable.

Eleven chapters of why before the first command. Paul will not give you one what until the why is unmistakable. The order is not an accident. It is the gospel.

Theologians have a pair of words for this, the indicative and the imperative. The indicative is what is true, what God has done, who you now are. The imperative is what you are therefore to do. And the entire logic of the New Testament is that the indicative comes first and the imperative grows out of it like fruit out of a root, never the other way around. You do not obey in order to become accepted. You obey because you have been accepted. You are not working toward the love. You are working from it. Reverse those and you do not have Christianity at all, you have religion, the oldest and most exhausting thing there is.

We preach it backwards constantly. We lead with the imperative, do this, stop that, try harder, and we mention the indicative at the end as motivation, a little fuel for the doing. Paul would not recognize it. For him the indicative is not motivation for the obedience. It is the reason the obedience is even possible, and the only soil it can grow in. Eleven chapters first. Always the why first. The therefore comes when the why is done and not one verse before.

Chapter Five: The Law Cannot Start the Sentence

People assume the Old Testament is where God leads with rules, and that the gospel comes later to soften them. Go back and read how the law itself is actually given, because it is not what you were told.

God brings Israel to the mountain and prepares to give the Ten Commandments, the very heart of the law, the most famous list of what's in human history. And watch the first thing he says before a single command. I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery. That is the preamble, and it is not decoration. Before one rule is given, God names who he is and what he has already done. I am the One who already saved you. I already broke your chains. I already carried you out on eagles' wings while you did nothing but be carried. That is the why, and it comes before the what, even here, even at Sinai, even in the law.

So the commandments are not the terms of a deal in which Israel earns its freedom by obeying. The freedom came first, by grace, unearned, while they were still slaves with nothing to offer. The commandments are the shape of a life lived by people who have already been set free. They are not how you get out of Egypt. They are how a person who is already out of Egypt learns to stop living like a slave. The order is everything. Grace, then law. Rescue, then response. Why, then what.

Before one rule is given at Sinai, God says I already

*brought you out. The law is not how you earn the rescue.
It is the shape of a life already rescued.*

Cut the preamble off and you have changed the religion entirely. A law with no I-already-saved-you in front of it is just a list of demands, and a list of demands produces exactly two kinds of people, the proud who think they are keeping it and the crushed who know they are not, and God has no use for either. The Pharisee and the despairing sinner are the same person, both of them living under a what with the why torn off, one of them lying about it and one of them honest. Jesus spent his ministry rescuing both from the same prison.

This is why moralism is not a mild error. It is not the gospel with the volume turned down. It is a different message wearing the gospel's clothes, and it does the opposite of what the gospel does. The gospel says you are loved, therefore live like it. Moralism says live like it, and then perhaps you will be loved. One of those sets a person free and one of them grinds a person down, and from the outside they can look almost identical, the same church, the same Bible, the same words, and underneath, the difference between heaven and hell. The whole difference is which question comes first.

Chapter Six: The Burnout of the What

I want to talk about exhaustion, because I think it is the most honest symptom of a faith built in the wrong order, and I have felt it myself and watched it in better people than me.

There is a particular kind of tiredness that comes over a Christian who has been doing all the right things for a long time without remembering why. It is not the tiredness of hard work, which a person can bear for years if the work means something. It is the tiredness of meaning gone out of the work while the work goes on. You are still at the post. You are still serving, still leading, still keeping the disciplines, and somewhere along the way the why drained out and now it is all what, all duty, all the grinding machinery of obligation with nothing underneath it but the fear of what stopping would mean. I have pastored people in that condition. I have been in that condition behind the pulpit, preaching the why to others while running on empty myself.

We have built a whole Christian culture that produces this. Look at the shelf, the conference, the feed, and count how much of it is what to do and how little is why it is so. Practical, we call it, as if the why were impractical, as if the reason a thing matters were a luxury for people with time to think. So we hand each other an endless stream of application, steps and habits and challenges and plans, and we wonder why everyone is so tired, why the most committed people burn out the hardest, why the ones who tried the most things have the least left. They ran the what without the why, and the what without the why is a fire with no

fuel. It burns bright for a season on the dry wood of willpower, and then there is nothing left to burn.

The what without the why is a fire with no fuel. It burns bright on the dry wood of willpower, and then there is nothing left to burn.

The cure is not to do less. People in this exhaustion are often told to rest, to add self-care to the pile of whats, and it does not touch the problem because it is the same kind of answer, another what for a wound that is a why. The cure is to go back down to the reason. To stop, not doing, but striving, and to ask the question we skipped, why am I doing any of this, and to refuse to move again until the answer is the gospel and not fear. Sometimes a believer has to let the whole machine of duty stop and sit in the rubble long enough to remember that he was loved before he ever did one useful thing, and will be loved if he never does another. That is not the enemy of obedience. It is the only ground obedience can grow in without killing the one who obeys.

I have learned to be suspicious of my own busyness in the faith. When I am most frantic to do, it is usually because I have lost touch with why, and the doing has become a way of not noticing. The frantic what is almost always a sign of a starved why. Slow down enough and you will feel where the foundation went hollow.

Chapter Seven: Why the Cross

Here is the question at the center of everything, and notice that the deepest form of it is a why and not a what.

The shallow version is a what. What must I do to be saved. It is a real question and the Bible answers it, but if it is the first question you bring to the cross you will misunderstand the whole thing, because the cross is not primarily an answer to what I must do. It is an answer to why God would do this. Why would the One who needs nothing, who is complete in himself, who was wronged in every way by the people he made, why would he come down into the wreckage and take the death that belonged to us. There is no what that explains that. No technique gets you there. It is the most unnecessary act in the history of the universe, unnecessary in the sense that nothing forced it, nothing required it, no system of cosmic accounting demanded that God love us at his own expense. He simply did. The cross is the why of God made visible, and it is the only why deep enough to hold a human life.

When I was an atheist I thought the Christian message was a what, a list of beliefs and behaviors that bought you a ticket out of hell, and I found it both unbelievable and beneath contempt. What broke me was not finally getting the what right. It was being undone by the why. The realization, slow and then all at once, that the story was not about what I had to do for God but about what God had already done for me, a man who had spent his whole life with his back to him, and that the doing had cost God everything and was offered to me for nothing. You do not argue someone into that. You cannot. It is not a conclusion at the

end of a what. It is a why so large it rearranges the person who finally sees it.

The cross is not first an answer to what I must do. It is the answer to why God would do this, and it is the only why deep enough to hold a human life.

This is why I am wary of any presentation of the gospel that leads with the what, the prayer to pray, the steps to take, the box to check. Not because those things are false but because they put the small question first and let people think they have understood. A man can say the prayer and get the what exactly right and never once have been undone by the why, and what he has then is not faith, it is a transaction he half believes will pay off later. The thief on the cross got no what right. He could do nothing, change nothing, fix nothing, perform nothing. He only saw, at the very end, the why, who this dying man beside him actually was, and threw himself on it. Today you will be with me in paradise. The whole gospel is in that exchange, and there is not one what in it.

So when your faith feels thin, do not run first to do more. Run to the cross and ask the older question. Not what must I do. Why would he do this. Stay there until it undoes you again, because it will, and the doing that flows out of being undone is the only doing that was ever worth anything.

Chapter Eight: Children Ask Why

I have five sons, and small children are the last people on earth who still ask the right question, and we spend their whole childhood training it out of them.

A young child asks why a hundred times a day, and it can drive a tired parent to the edge, because the why does not stop. Why is the sky dark. Why did the dog die. Why do I have to. Why, why, why, down and down, past the place where we have answers and into the place where we have only God or nothing. And what do we do, most of us, exhausted by the relentless reaching of it. We answer with a what. Because I said so. Because those are the rules. Because that is just how it is. We shut the why down with a what, over and over, until the child learns that why is a door that gets closed in your face and stops knocking. And then we wonder, fifteen years later, why our young person has no curiosity about God, no hunger underneath the religion, only a sullen competence at the whats we drilled into him.

I am not innocent here. I have answered my sons with because I said so when I was too tired to give them the why, and every time I do it I feel something close in them a little, the same thing the serpent closed in Eve, the trust that there is a good reason underneath the rule. A child can obey a what for a while on the strength of fear or love of the parent, but if you never give him the why, the obedience has no roots, and the day your authority weakens, which is the day he turns thirteen, the whole thing comes up out of the ground because there was nothing holding it down.

*We shut the why down with a what, over and over,
until the child learns that why is a door that gets closed
in his face, and stops knocking.*

So I am trying, badly and slowly, to do the opposite with my boys. To treat the why not as an annoyance to be managed but as the most important muscle they have, the one the gospel will one day need them to use. When my son asks why we forgive someone who has not said sorry, I could give him the rule, we forgive because we are supposed to, and shut the door. Or I can take the harder ten minutes and give him the why, that we forgive because we were forgiven a debt we could never have paid, by a God who did not wait for us to say sorry but died for us while we were still his enemies, and that an unforgiving forgiven person has not understood the thing that saved him. The first answer makes a boy who behaves. The second answer, if it lands, makes a man who believes. I want sons who believe, and that means I have to honor the why even when I am tired, especially when I am tired.

The kingdom belongs to children, Jesus said, and I used to hear that as a word about humility, which it is. But I have come to hear something else in it too. Children still ask why. They have not yet been talked out of the only question that reaches God. Become like them, Jesus says, and maybe part of what he means is, start asking why again, the way you did before the world taught you to settle for what.

Chapter Nine: The Skeptic's Real Question

I spend a great deal of my life talking with people who do not believe, and I love them, and I was one of them, and I will tell you the single most common mistake the church makes with them. We answer their what when they are asking why.

The skeptic comes with what sound like what questions. What about the contradictions in the Bible. What about science. What about all the harm religion has done. And the well-meaning Christian, eager and armed, answers the what. Here is the resolution to that contradiction. Here is the compatibility of faith and science. Here is the historical context for that atrocity. And none of it works, and the believer walks away thinking the skeptic was just hard-hearted, and the skeptic walks away thinking the believer did not hear him, and the skeptic is right, because underneath every what he raised was a why he could not say out loud. Why did my prayers hit the ceiling. Why is there so much suffering if someone good is in charge. Why would I trust people who hurt me in God's name. Why does my life feel like it means nothing. The what questions were the door. The why was the room, and we kept answering at the door.

I know this because it was true of me. I could argue the whats all night, and I did, and I won most of those arguments and stayed exactly as lost as before, because no argument about a what was ever going to reach the why I was actually living, the fatherless ache, the suspicion that there was no reason for any of it, the fear that the universe was exactly as cold as it looked. You do not

answer that with evidence for the resurrection, though the resurrection is true and the evidence is real. You answer it the way Jesus answered people, by going underneath the question they asked to the wound they were protecting, and speaking to that.

Every what the skeptic raises is a door. The why is the room. We keep answering at the door and wonder why no one comes inside.

This is not a reason to abandon the whats. The church should be able to give an account, and a Christianity that cannot think is not worth defending. But the apologetics that actually reaches a person is the kind that hears the why under the what and is unafraid to go there, to say, I think the contradictions are not really what is keeping you up, I think it is that you cannot see why a good God would let your mother die the way she did, and I am not going to insult you with a tidy answer, but I will tell you about a God who came down into exactly that kind of death himself. That is a different conversation. It does not always end in faith. But it ends in being heard, which is more than most skeptics have ever gotten from a Christian, and the Spirit does a great deal with being heard.

If you love someone who does not believe, stop trying to win the what. Listen for the why. It is almost never the question they are asking out loud, and it is always the only one that matters.

Chapter Ten: Worship Is What the Why Sounds Like

If the whole point of a human being is a why, to glorify God and enjoy him forever, then the native response of a person who has finally seen the why is not a task. It is worship. And worship is the thing we keep trying to turn back into a what.

Watch what happens to Paul at the end of those eleven chapters in Romans. He is reasoning, building, arguing, and then the why gets so large that the argument breaks open and he stops explaining and starts adoring. Oh, the depth of the riches and wisdom and knowledge of God. He is not telling you to do anything. He is doing the thing himself, the thing the whole why is for, he is worshiping, and the doxology is not a break from the theology, it is where the theology was always going. All real thinking about God, pushed far enough, turns into praise. If your theology never turns into worship, you have been doing it as a what, gathering information about a God you have not yet seen, and the information will puff you up and leave you cold, because that is what knowledge without love always does.

This is why I have come to distrust a certain kind of doctrinal precision that never once breaks into song. You can be exactly right about God and completely dead to him, holding all the correct whats about a Person you have never adored, and the demons can do that, the book of James says, the demons believe and shudder, they have the doctrine letter perfect and it only terrifies them because there is no why in it, no love, no glad amazement, just accurate information about a Judge. Right belief

that never becomes worship is demonic in the precise and literal sense. It is the one place the orthodox and the damned stand on the same ground.

If your theology never turns into worship, you have been doing it as a what. All real thinking about God, pushed far enough, turns into praise.

And worship is also where the why protects the what, finally, and makes obedience possible. The person who has been brought to adoration is the only person who can obey without resentment, because for him the commands are no longer a fence, they are the wishes of the One he loves, and a lover does not chafe at the wishes of the beloved, he reaches for them. This is the whole secret the moralist never finds. He is trying to obey his way into a love he has never felt. The worshiper is obeying out of a love that has already overwhelmed him, and so the same commandments that crush the one delight the other. The difference, again and always, is the why. Worship is the why made audible, and it changes the meaning of every what that follows.

So I have stopped measuring my spiritual health by how much I am doing and started measuring it by whether I am still capable of being amazed. When the wonder goes, the why has gone, and the doing that is left, however correct, is already dying. Keep the wonder and the rest takes care of itself. Lose it and no amount of right behavior will hide the hollowness for long.

Chapter Eleven: When the Why Goes Dark

I have to be honest about the hardest case, because a book that only worked when life was explicable would not be worth your trust. Sometimes you ask why and heaven says nothing.

There is a suffering that comes with no reason attached, and the believer who has learned to live by the why runs straight into the wall of it. The diagnosis with no lesson in it. The child who does not come home. The prayer prayed for years into a silence that never breaks. And every instinct the faith has built in you cries out for the why, and the why does not come, and now what. This is where a great deal of Christianity quietly collapses, because we promised people a God who explains himself, a reason for everything, a tidy why behind every wound, and when the why goes dark they conclude there was never anyone there.

But look at Job, the longest treatment of suffering in the Bible, and notice what God does and does not give him. Job demands a why for forty chapters, a reason, an explanation, an account of what he did to deserve it. And when God finally speaks out of the whirlwind, he gives Job no why at all. Not one. He never tells him about the wager in the heavens, never explains the suffering, never hands over the reason Job has been screaming for. Instead he gives Job himself. Where were you when I laid the foundations of the earth. Chapter after chapter, not an explanation but a Presence, not a why but a Who. And it is enough. Job says, I had heard of you with the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you. He never gets the answer. He gets the

Answerer, and it turns out that was the thing the question was really reaching for all along.

Job demanded a why and God gave him no why at all. He gave him himself. The deepest why was never a reason. It was a Person.

This is the deepest turn in the whole argument, and I have only learned it by needing it. The why we are made for is not finally a reason. It is a Person. When you trace the why down past every explanation, past the catechism and the doctrine and the argument, you do not arrive at a proposition. You arrive at a face. The reason for everything is not a because. It is a Who, the God who made you for himself, and the restlessness Augustine named is the ache of a why that will not be satisfied by any answer smaller than God's own self. Which means that even when the explanation never comes, the why is not denied. It is answered in the only currency that could ever have satisfied it, the Presence of the One you were made for, drawing nearer in the dark than he ever felt in the light.

So when your why goes unanswered, do not conclude there is no answer. Conclude that your why was always too deep for a reason and was only ever going to be filled by a Person, and that the silence where the explanation should be is not empty. He is in it. He has been in it the whole time. That is not a reason. It is better than a reason. It is the thing every reason was a substitute for.

Chapter Twelve: Begin Again With Why

So here is what I am asking, at the end. Go back and reorder the questions. Put the why where it belongs, first, in front of everything, and let the what come after, where it can finally stand.

This is not a technique, and I am aware of the irony of ending a book against the what with anything that sounds like a what to do. So let me say it as a turning rather than a task. Most of us have our faith arranged in exactly the wrong order. The whats are up front, loud and anxious and exhausting, the rules and the steps and the performances, and the why is back somewhere in the dark, assumed, unexamined, starved. And the whole thing wobbles, and we keep trying to fix the wobble by adding more whats, more discipline, more steps, more trying, when the wobble was never in the what. It was in the why we skipped. You cannot fix a foundation problem on the upper floors.

To begin again with why is to go down to the bottom and ask the questions we were too busy or too afraid to ask. Why did God make me. Why did Christ die. Why does any of this matter when no one is watching. And to refuse to move, to refuse to add one more what to the pile, until the why is answered not with information but with the kind of seeing that undoes a person. Because once the why is real, the what takes care of itself. The man who has been undone by why God would die for him does not need to be nagged into obedience. It comes out of him like water out of a spring. That is the order the whole Bible insists

on, grace then law, indicative then imperative, the eleven chapters then the therefore, the I-brought-you-out before the commandments, the why before the what, every time, without exception, in every place it matters.

Once the why is real, the what takes care of itself. The man undone by why God would die for him does not need to be nagged into obedience. It comes out of him like water from a spring.

I came to faith from atheism because someone, finally, stopped answering my whats and let me feel the weight of the why. I was raised without a father and I spent my life asking what is wrong with me when the question underneath was why am I alone, and the gospel did not answer the what. It answered the why, with a Father who had been there the entire time. I have five sons, and the thing I most want to leave them is not a set of rules they can keep, though I hope they keep them. It is a why so deep that the rules will keep themselves, a reason for their existence large enough that no grief can knock it flat and no skeptic can argue it away, because it was never an argument, it was a Person who made them for himself.

I am still learning to ask the question in the right order. I revert to the what under pressure, the way we all do, grasping for steps when I should be sinking down to the reason. But I know now which question is the real one, and I will spend the rest of my life trying to ask it first. Not what. Why. Start there, and stay there until it answers, and you will find that everything you were trying to build on the what was waiting all along to be built on the why instead, where it should have stood from the beginning, where it can finally hold.